THE SHE LIST

Turnaround Banker

Zarin Daruwala, *58*
Cluster CEO, India and South Asia markets, Standard Chartered Bank



MILIND SHELTE

ZARIN DARUWALA KNOWS HOW TO TURN THE TABLES on adversities. Maybe because her go-to motto comes from double amputee mountaineer Mark Inglis whose message was "your attitude determines your altitude". Since she took over as the Cluster CEO of Standard Chartered Bank for India and South Asia Markets in April 2016, it has been a roller-coaster ride for Zarin. One of India's oldest foreign banks (at 165 years), StanChart was going through a challenging phase, marked by mounting bad debts and increasing losses. However, the bank's journey over the last few years has been nothing short of extraordinary. Its profit before tax increased sixfold from Rs 1,122 crore in FY16 to Rs 6,368 crore in FY23. Gross NPAs to advances also dipped dramatically from a high of 14.1 per cent to 3.6 per cent. Standard Chartered is not only back to sustained growth and profits, but India also became one of the top three contributors to the group's operating income, after Hong Kong and Singapore last year.

According to Zarin, the major initiatives that brought the bank back to profitability were de-risking the asset base by reducing NPAs and seeking a good mix between retail and corporate clients. Additionally, several initiatives were taken to rework sub-optimal products to make them more market-relevant and economical for the bank. Regarding the balance sheet, the focus was on increasing the retail customer base, current account balances and high-quality asset growth.

Steering digitalisation was another area for growth with a focus on key areas, including onboarding, online customer servicing, video KYC and payments, which proved beneficial post-2019. "Digital banking adoption among our customers stands at 75 per cent, 10 per cent higher than the market average," she says. Recently, they also invested in a credit card management system to support transaction processing and card servicing. No wonder, the retail banking business saw a turnaround, increasing its profitability. She proudly says, "For the financial year 2022-23, SC India is the second-most profitable foreign bank in India basis locally reported results while for FY22, it was the most profitable foreign bank in the country." And the 'credit' goes to Zarin. ■

–Sonal Khetarpal

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Under her stewardship, StanChart is back to posting sustained growth after a challenging phase

AIMING HIGH

"Once I expressed my doubt if I could reach my first boss Lalita D. Gupte's position, that of a general manager. She gave me a light rap on my knuckles saying, 'Never aim low and never say that again'"

MENTOR AND GUIDE
Y.H. Malegam, whom she calls one of India's most respected chartered accountants. He advised her to join ICICI (now ICICI Bank), where there were already many women in senior positions